

nas; he distinguishes between the views of philosophers and those of theologians and indicates what parts of the views of Aristotle or Averroes may be maintained. This book belongs in every scholarly library.

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GIAN LUCA POTESTÀ, *Il tempo dell'Apocalisse: Vita di Gioacchino da Fiore*. (Collezione Storica.) Rome and Bari: Laterza, 2004. Pp. x, 502 plus 24 black-and-white and color figures; tables. €48.

Gian Luca Potestà has investigated a series of apocalyptic thinkers perched on the edge of doctrinal respectability. He published a very competent book on the Spiritual Franciscan spokesman Ubertino da Casale and followed it with what may be the best book to date on another great Spiritual Franciscan, Angelo Clareno. He also has done good work on Arnold of Villanova. In all these endeavors Potestà has shown that he is thoroughly conversant with the sources, well informed concerning earlier scholarship, and willing to accept previous conclusions when he finds them compelling, yet at the same time he is capable of rethinking matters, reformulating problems, and reaching his own conclusions.

In this book he moves back to the late twelfth and early thirteenth centuries to produce an intellectual biography of the Calabrian abbot and apocalyptic thinker Joachim of Fiore, one of the most intriguing yet enigmatic figures in Western intellectual history. Joachim has been studied to good effect by Bernard McGinn, Robert Lerner, and others, but there is still room for Potestà to make an important contribution, and he does. He combines attention to Joachim's life and times with a painstaking effort to explore the development of his thought. In the process he spends a great deal of time, not merely on Joachim's major writings, but on the entire corpus of his work, and in the process Potestà pays close attention to questions of dating. He is aware that Joachim's later writings were often composed by combining and expanding on earlier works. Thus not only the writings but their component parts must sometimes be dated and examined more or less as independent works. He is also aware that each of Joachim's three major literary achievements—the *Psalterium*, the *Concordia*, and the Apocalypse commentary—evolved gradually and lacks internal consistency. The Apocalypse commentary, for example, was begun in the early 1180s and not finished until shortly before Joachim's death in 1202, thus allowing him adequate time to rethink his position on a number of issues along the way. We must be prepared to discover that the apocalyptic role assigned to the Holy Roman Empire in part 6 of the commentary is not identical with the one it received in part 5.

Given the magnitude and complexity of the project dictated by these considerations, it is amazing that the book moves along as smoothly and engagingly as it does. Potestà is a good writer who engages our interest and manages to keep us informed as to where he is at all times. The result is a remarkable guided tour of Joachim's intellectual pilgrimage from the 1170s through his death in 1202. Potestà presents us with a Joachim who arrived at some of his most important ideas early, hit upon others only in time, and was never afraid to change his mind. He became fascinated with the Trinity early and progressively discovered its implications for a theology of history, but he originally combined it with an essentially binary division of history. This binary view would remain important for him, but he would eventually link his Trinitarian thought with another, more potentially radical threefold division as well.

As to how Joachim arrived at this threefold division, Potestà argues that he first linked the three Persons of the Trinity with the three orders of laity, clerics, and monks, then moved from there to a further link with the three ages of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Potestà emphasizes that this final move introduced a temporal, developmental dimension

somewhat different from the three orders in that, whereas the orders (like the Trinity itself) continue to exist throughout time, the three ages do not. Here Potestà makes a point at variance with what is argued by some contemporary Joachim scholars who are uncomfortable with the idea of three distinct ages linked with the three Persons of the Trinity and who prefer to think of Joachim's three *status* more as states or levels of being than as periods. Potestà observes that Joachim himself refers to the *status* as *tempora*.

Potestà's emphasis on the importance of the three orders in Joachim's thought represents an important part of his contribution. Another is the attention he gives to the political and religious milieu in which Joachim wrote. Joachim was sensitive to that milieu, and changes in it can often be linked with changes in his apocalyptic program. Thus the papacy, the Holy Roman Empire, the Cathar heresy, the Muslims (or particular Muslims like Saladin), and the Greek church waxed and waned in apocalyptic importance as Joachim observed current events. Nevertheless, Potestà is also aware that Joachim was deeply rooted in the monastic world of his time and saw the world essentially from that perspective. His work is very much about monasticism and its role in history.

Right to the end, Joachim was still revising his work and pondering its implications. Potestà brings the story to Joachim's death, then simply stops. The effect is somewhat jarring. While I am grateful for all I have received to that point, I would have welcomed a final chapter, perhaps summarizing Potestà's thoughts on Joachim and his historical significance.

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TIMOTHY J. REISS, *Mirages of the Self: Patterns of Personhood in Ancient and Early Modern Europe*. Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press, 2003. Pp. xxi, 608; black-and-white frontispiece and 13 black-and-white figures. \$70.

In the wake of poststructuralism, medieval and early-modern critical studies have resonated with books and articles based on insights of psychoanalytic and other theories predicated autonomous being. This trend adopts modern philosophy's conception of the human person as either a thinking subject who perceives himself or herself in a larger social context and is consequently capable of making universal moral judgments (e.g., Descartes and Kant) or, rather, following Leibniz, Hegel, and Nietzsche, as a radically independent individual who shares with others only what he or she consciously decides to grant.

Heidegger, Lacan, Foucault, Derrida and other poststructuralists famously built their systems on the second branch, and it is their methods that have most influenced recent scholarship in our discipline. In consequence, terms such as "subject," "subjectivity," "subject position," "person," "self," "individual," and numerous related concepts, for example, "authority," "the body," "gender," "sexuality," and so on, have played an ever greater role in the discourse of early-modern studies. This role has, by and large, been salutary insofar as it has opened avenues of inquiry into areas and texts previously considered marginal, while challenging traditional definitions of "significant texts."

The role of women in politics and culture, the impact of minorities in medieval society, a robustly diverse sexuality, the literary interest of works previously excluded from "the canon" are but a few of the topics that poststructuralism has opened to investigation, thereby revitalizing the discipline, as Richard Emmerson notes in a forthcoming article in the *Journal of English and Germanic Philology*.

Since the positive contribution of such studies is no longer in question, it is now possible to query certain epistemological issues they raise. To the extent that poststructuralism grounds itself on definitions of personhood implicated in a critique of Enlightenment humanism, its various formulations—and they are richly diverse—nonetheless share a view